

SENATE CHAMBER
STATE OF OKLAHOMA

DISPOSITION

☒ FLOOR AMENDMENT

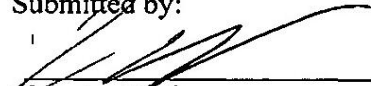
No. 1

☐ COMMITTEE AMENDMENT

(Date)

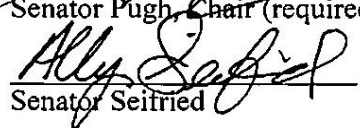
I move to amend Senate Bill No. 1778, by substituting the attached floor substitute (Request #3844) for the title, enacting clause, and entire body of the measure.

Submitted by:


Senator Pugh

I hereby grant permission for the floor substitute to be adopted.

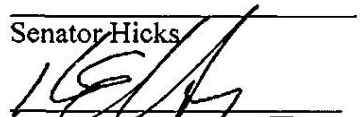

Senator Pugh, Chair (required)

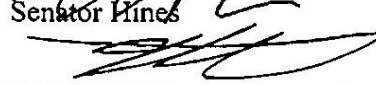

Senator Seifried

Senator Deevers

Senator Dossett

Senator Hicks


Senator Hines


Senator Paxton, President Pro Tempore

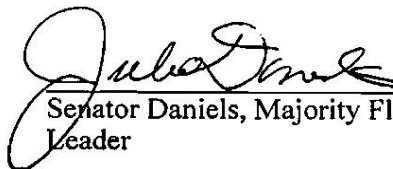
Senator Mann

Senator Pederson

Senator Rader

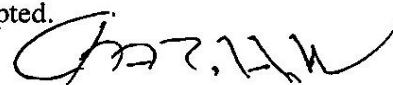

Senator Reinhardt

Senator Sacchieri


Senator Daniels, Majority Floor
Leader

Note: Education committee majority requires six (6) members' signatures.

I hereby grant permission for the floor substitute to be adopted.


Senator Hall
Appropriations Committee Chair

Pugh-EB-FS-SB1778
3/24/2026 9:24 AM

(Floor Amendments Only)

Date and Time Filed: 3/24/26 6:44pm fd

☐ Untimely

☐ Amendment Cycle Extended

☐ Secondary Amendment

STATE OF OKLAHOMA

2nd Session of the 60th Legislature (2026)

FLOOR SUBSTITUTE
FOR

SENATE BILL NO. 1778

By: Pugh of the Senate

and

Hilbert, Staires, and
Hasenbeck of the House

FLOOR SUBSTITUTE

[Strong Readers Act - screening instruments -
reading intervention programs - strong readers plan -
retention review - exemptions - parental notification
- funding weights - summer academies - professional
development - literacy instructional teams -
codification -
emergency]

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

SECTION 1. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508A,
as amended by Section 3, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
2025, Section 1210.508A), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508A. Sections 1210.508A through ~~1210.508H~~
1210.508J of this title shall be known and may be cited as the
"Strong Readers Act".

1 SECTION 2. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508B,
2 as amended by Section 4, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
3 2025, Section 1210.508B), is amended to read as follows:

4 Section 1210.508B. A. The Legislature finds that it is
5 essential for children in the public schools to read early and well
6 in elementary school. The Legislature further finds that clear and
7 visible goals, assessments to determine the reading level at each
8 elementary school, use of a scientifically based and researched
9 methodology in reading instruction in addition to regular and
10 periodic measurements of elementary school reading improvement, and
11 accountability in each level of the educational system will result
12 in a significant increase in the number of children reading at or
13 above grade level.

14 B. The purpose of the Strong Readers Act is to ensure that
15 progression from one grade to another is determined, in part, upon
16 proficiency in reading, that school district board of education
17 policies facilitate reading instruction and intervention services to
18 address student reading needs, and that each student and his or her
19 parent or legal guardian be informed of that student's reading
20 progress. It is the intent of the Legislature that every student
21 reads at or above grade level by the end of third grade.

22 C. To carry out the purpose of this act, it is the intent of
23 the Legislature that the identification, instruction, and
24 intervention required under the Strong Readers Act be implemented

1 within a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS) framework that
2 emphasizes strong core literacy instruction for all students and
3 provides increasing levels of instructional intensity based on
4 student need and demonstrated response to instruction.

5 D. It is further the intent of the Legislature that strong core
6 literacy instruction consists of explicit, systematic instruction in
7 foundational reading and writing skills including phonological
8 awareness, decoding, encoding, spelling, sentence-level writing,
9 language development, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension,
10 recognizing the reciprocal relationship between reading and writing
11 proficiency.

12 E. Each public school district in this state shall ensure that
13 all students receive a well-rounded education that is focused on
14 building deep foundations in reading, writing, and mathematics. The
15 State Board of Education shall encourage school districts to
16 integrate the teaching of the other curricular areas in the subject
17 matter standards adopted by the Board with the instruction of
18 reading, writing, and mathematics. All teachers of reading in the
19 public schools in this state in kindergarten through third grade
20 shall incorporate into instruction the five elements of reading
21 instruction which are phonological awareness, decoding, fluency,
22 vocabulary, and comprehension.

23 ~~D.~~ F. It is the intent of the Legislature that beginning with
24 the 2025-2026 school year, school districts and charter schools in

1 this state shall be prohibited from using the three-cueing system
2 model of teaching students to read. For the purposes of this
3 section, the "three-cueing system" means any model of teaching
4 students to read based on meaning, structure, syntax, and visual
5 cues, which may also be known as meaning, structure, and visual
6 (MSV), balanced literacy, or whole language.

7 SECTION 3. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified
8 in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 1210.508B-1 of Title 70, unless
9 there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

10 A. As used in the Strong Readers Act:

11 1. "Grade-level targets" means the grade-specific benchmark
12 scores established for the screening instrument selected by the
13 State Board of Education in coordination with the Commission for
14 Educational Quality and Accountability;

15 2. "Highly qualified teacher" means a teacher or provider with
16 appropriate training and demonstrated competency in evidence-based
17 reading intervention;

18 3. "Literacy coach" means an educator with demonstrated
19 expertise in evidence-based literacy instruction who provides job-
20 embedded professional learning, modeling, observation, and feedback
21 to teachers to strengthen core instruction and intervention
22 practices within a multi-tiered system of supports framework. The
23 primary responsibility of a literacy coach is to support educators
24 and administrators in improving instructional practices and

1 schoolwide literacy systems. A literacy coach shall not serve in a
2 supervisory or evaluative capacity to maintain a non-evaluative role
3 that fosters professional trust and growth;

4 4. "Multi-tiered system of supports" or "MTSS" means a
5 framework that provides strong core literacy instruction to all
6 students and increasingly intensive levels of instructional support
7 based on student need and demonstrated response to instruction;

8 5. "Reading deficiency" means performance below grade-level
9 targets on a screening or diagnostic assessment indicating that a
10 student is not meeting grade-level expectations in one or more
11 reading skill areas;

12 6. "Reading interventionist" means an educator trained in
13 evidence-based reading instruction who provides supplemental or
14 intensive intervention to students identified with a reading
15 deficiency or significant reading deficiency, aligned to student
16 data and delivered in addition to core instruction;

17 7. "Reading specialist" means an educator who has completed
18 advanced preparation in literacy instruction and assessment and is
19 responsible for designing, delivering, and monitoring targeted and
20 intensive reading intervention services, as well as supporting
21 teachers in addressing reading deficiencies across grade levels. A
22 reading specialist shall have completed a graduate-level specialist
23 degree in reading or literacy and passed the applicable
24

1 certification examination and shall hold a valid teaching
2 certificate with a reading specialist endorsement;

3 8. "Science of reading" means the body of scientifically based
4 research conducted over several decades and across multiple
5 countries, drawing from multiple disciplines including cognitive
6 psychology, linguistics, neuroscience, and education, that explains
7 how individuals learn to read and write. The science of reading
8 informs instructional practices that are explicit, systematic, and
9 cumulative, and are aligned to the development of phonological
10 awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, comprehension, written
11 expression, and oral language development;

12 9. "Significant reading deficiency" means a reading deficiency
13 that persists despite supplemental intervention and indicates a need
14 for intensive intervention based on student data and response to
15 instruction;

16 10. "Tier 1 - Core Instruction" or "Tier 1" means:

- 17 a. the evidence-based reading instruction provided to all
18 students as part of the general education program.
19 Tier 1 instruction shall include high-quality,
20 standards-aligned literacy instruction grounded in the
21 science of reading and delivered during the regular
22 instructional day,
- 23 b. Tier 1 shall include universal screening in
24 kindergarten through third grade and ongoing

assessment used to identify students who may require additional instructional support. Tier 1 may also include targeted instructional supports delivered within the core instructional setting to address emerging reading needs, and

- c. Tier 1 instruction is intended to meet the needs of the majority of students through strong classroom instruction and prevention-focused supports;

11. "Tier 2 - Supplemental Intervention" or "Tier 2" means:

- a. targeted reading intervention provided in addition to Tier 1 core instruction for students identified through screening and progress-monitoring data as requiring additional instructional support to meet grade-level reading expectations. Tier 2 intervention shall:

- (1) provide additional instructional time beyond Tier 1 core instruction,
- (2) be delivered in small-group settings, typically consisting of three to five students, using evidence-based instructional practices aligned with the science of reading,
- (3) target specific skill deficits identified through assessment data, and

- (4) include regular progress monitoring to determine the effectiveness of the intervention and guide instructional adjustments, and
 - b. a student shall be designated as receiving Tier 2 supplemental intervention only when the student is actively participating in scheduled intervention services beyond Tier 1 instruction; and
12. "Tier 3 - Intensive Intervention" or "Tier 3" means:
 - a. individualized or highly targeted reading intervention provided in addition to Tier 1 core instruction and Tier 2 supplemental intervention for students demonstrating a significant reading deficiency. Tier 3 intervention shall:
 - (1) provide substantially increased instructional intensity and frequency beyond Tier 2 supports,
 - (2) be delivered in individualized or small group settings, typically consisting of one to three students,
 - (3) be guided by diagnostic assessment to address specific reading skill deficits, and
 - (4) include frequent progress monitoring to evaluate student response to intervention and guide instructional decision-making, and

1 b. a student shall be designated as receiving Tier 3
2 intensive intervention only when the student is
3 actively participating in scheduled intensive
4 intervention services beyond Tier 1 instruction.

5 B. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules
6 establishing implementation guidance for each tier defined in
7 paragraphs 10 through 12 of subsection A of this section including
8 expectations related to instructional time, group size,
9 documentation requirements, and progress-monitoring practices
10 necessary to ensure the effective delivery of intervention services.

11 SECTION 4. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508C,
12 as last amended by Section 2, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S.
13 Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508C), is amended to read as follows:

14 Section 1210.508C. A. To identify students who have a reading
15 deficiency or characteristics of dyslexia that lead to or cause
16 reading difficulty, each student enrolled in kindergarten and first,
17 second, and third grade in a public school in this state shall be
18 screened at the beginning, middle, and end of each school year for
19 monitoring of progress and for measurement of reading skills
20 ~~including, but not limited to, phonological awareness, decoding,~~
21 ~~fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension. A screening instrument~~
22 ~~approved by the State Board of Education, in consultation with the~~
23 ~~Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability and the~~
24 ~~Secretary of Education, shall.~~ The Office of Educational Quality

1 and Accountability shall evaluate and rank up to three screening
2 instruments, which shall be approved by the Commission for
3 Educational Quality and Accountability. The State Board of
4 Education shall select one screening instrument approved by the
5 Commission to be utilized for the purposes of this section.

6 The selected screening instrument shall meet the following
7 criteria:

8 1. Can assess for phonological awareness, sound-symbol
9 recognition, alphabet knowledge, rapid naming skills, decoding and
10 encoding skills, oral reading accuracy and fluency, vocabulary, and
11 comprehension, as developmentally appropriate;

12 2. Can document the validity and reliability of each
13 assessment;

14 3. Can identify students who are at risk for reading and math
15 deficiency and monitor student progress throughout the school year;

16 4. Can be linked to, and can accurately predict, performance on
17 the Oklahoma School Testing Program;

18 5. Is normed beyond elementary grades;

19 6. Can assess students with disabilities and English language
20 learners;

21 7. Is accompanied by a data management system that provides
22 profiles of each student, class, grade level, and school building.
23 The profiles shall identify the instructional point of need and
24 reading achievement level for each student;

1 8. Is capable of reporting student-level data to the State
2 Department of Education and the Office of Educational Quality and
3 Accountability; and

4 9. Cannot be completed autonomously by a student on an
5 electronic device.

6 B. In determining which screening instrument to approve and
7 utilize, the ~~State Board of Education, the~~ Commission for
8 Educational Quality and Accountability, and the ~~Secretary~~ State
9 Board of Education shall take into consideration at a minimum the
10 following factors:

11 1. The time required to conduct the screening instrument with
12 the intention of minimizing the impact on instructional time;

13 2. The timeliness in reporting screening instrument results to
14 teachers, administrators, and parents and legal guardians of
15 students; ~~and~~

16 3. The integration of the screening instrument into reading and
17 math curriculum.

18 ~~B. Beginning in the 2025-2026 school year, the State Board of~~
19 ~~Education shall approve no fewer than three screening instruments~~
20 ~~for use at the beginning, middle, and end of the school year for~~
21 ~~monitoring of progress and for measurement of reading skills as~~
22 ~~required in subsection A of this section. The screening instruments~~
23 ~~shall meet the following criteria:~~

1 ~~1. Assess for phonological awareness, decoding, fluency,~~
2 ~~vocabulary, and comprehension;~~

3 ~~2. Document the validity and reliability of each assessment;~~

4 ~~3. Can be used for identifying students who are at risk for~~
5 ~~reading deficiency and progress monitoring throughout the school~~
6 ~~year;~~

7 ~~4. Can be used to assess students with disabilities and English~~
8 ~~language learners; and~~

9 ~~5. Accompanied by a data management system that provides~~
10 ~~profiles of each student, class, grade level, and school building.~~

11 ~~The profiles shall identify each student's instructional point of~~
12 ~~need and reading achievement level. The State Board shall also~~
13 ~~determine other comparable reading assessments for diagnostic~~
14 ~~purposes to be used for students at risk of reading failure; and~~

15 4. The ability to report all reading screening results to both
16 the State Department of Education and the Office of Educational
17 Quality and Accountability.

18 C. 1. Exemptions to the screening requirements of this section
19 may be provided to students who have documented evidence that they
20 meet at least one of the following criteria as related to the
21 provision of classroom instruction:

22 a. the student participates in the Oklahoma Alternate
23 Assessment Program (OAAP) and is taught using
24 alternate methods,

- b. the student's primary expressive or receptive communication is sign language,
- c. the student's primary form of written or read text is Braille, or
- d. the student's primary expressive or receptive language is not English, the student is identified as an English learner using a state-approved identification assessment, and the student has had less than one (1) school year of instruction in an English-learner program.

2. A public school that grants an exemption pursuant to paragraph 1 of this subsection shall provide ongoing evidence of student progression toward English language acquisition with the same frequency as administration of screening assessments. Evidence may include, but not be limited to, student progression toward OAAP reading essential elements, proficiency in sign language and reading comprehension, and proficiency in Braille and reading comprehension.

D. 1. Students who are administered a screening instrument pursuant to subsection A of this section and are found not to be meeting grade-level targets shall be provided a program of reading ~~instruction designed to enable students to acquire the appropriate grade-level reading skills. The program of reading instruction shall be based on scientific reading research and align with the~~

~~subject matter standards adopted by the State Board of Education. A
program of reading instruction shall include:~~

- ~~a. sufficient additional in-school instructional time for
the acquisition of phonological awareness, decoding,
fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension,~~
- ~~b. if necessary and if funding is available, tutorial
instruction after regular school hours, on Saturdays,
and during summer; however, such instruction may not
be counted toward the one-hundred-eighty-day or one-
thousand-eighty-hour school year required in Section
1-109 of this title,~~
- ~~c. assessments identified for diagnostic purposes and
periodic monitoring to measure the acquisition of
reading skills including, but not limited to,
phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary,
and comprehension, as identified in the student's
program of reading instruction,~~
- ~~d. high-quality instructional materials grounded in
scientifically based reading research, and~~
- ~~e. a means of providing every family of a student in
prekindergarten, kindergarten, and first, second, and
third grade access to free online evidence-based
literacy instruction resources to support the
student's literacy development at home. intervention~~

1 services, as determined by their individual reading
2 intervention plan. Such reading intervention services
3 shall not occur during math instruction.

4 2. A student enrolled in kindergarten or first, second, or
5 third grade who exhibits a ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency at any
6 time based on the screening instrument administered pursuant to
7 subsection A of this section and any fourth-grade student promoted
8 for good cause pursuant to subsection L of this section shall
9 receive an individual reading intervention plan no later than thirty
10 (30) days after the identification of the ~~deficiency in~~ reading
11 deficiency. The reading intervention plan shall be provided in
12 addition to ~~core~~ Tier 1 reading instruction that is provided to all
13 students. The reading intervention plan shall:

- 14 a. describe the ~~research-based~~ reading intervention
15 services the student will receive to remedy the
16 ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency,
- 17 b. provide explicit and systematic instruction in
18 phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary,
19 and comprehension, as applicable,
- 20 c. monitor the reading progress of each student's reading
21 skills throughout the school year and adjust
22 instruction according to the student's needs, and
- 23 d. continue until the student is determined to be meeting
24 grade-level targets in reading based on the screening

~~instruments~~ instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section or assessments identified for diagnostic purposes and periodic monitoring ~~pursuant to subparagraph c of paragraph 1 of this subsection~~ by the State Board of Education.

3. The reading intervention plan for each student identified with a ~~deficiency in~~ reading deficiency shall be developed by a Student Reading Proficiency Team and shall include supplemental instructional services and supports. Each team shall be composed of:

- a. the parent or legal guardian of the student,
- b. the teacher assigned to the student who had responsibility for reading instruction in that academic year,
- c. a teacher who is responsible for reading instruction and is assigned to teach in the next grade level of the student, ~~and~~
- d. a certified reading specialist or an individual with advanced training or specialization in literacy instruction, ~~if one is available and~~
- e. the principal, vice principal, or designate.

~~4. A school district shall notify the parent or legal guardian of any student in kindergarten or first, second, or third grade who exhibits a deficiency in reading at any time based on the screening~~

~~instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section.~~
~~The notification shall occur no later than thirty (30) days after~~
~~the identification of the deficiency in reading.~~ The State Board of
Education, in consultation with the Office of Educational Quality
and Accountability, shall annually define and set benchmarks for
screening instrument results that are predictive of future
performance on the state summative assessment to assist in
identifying intervention tiers within a reading intervention plan.
Annually, the Office of Educational Quality and Accountability shall
analyze and report to the State Department of Education the
correlation of screening instrument tiers to state summative tiers
using predictive modeling and prior year formative and summative
testing results.

5. Reading intervention shall not be provided solely by digital
technology. Reading intervention shall include a majority of direct
instruction from a teacher or reading specialist trained in the
science of reading.

E. 1. Every school district shall adopt and implement a
district strong readers plan which has had input from school
administrators, teachers, and parents and legal guardians, and if
~~possible~~ a reading specialist or interventionist, and which shall be
submitted electronically to and approved by the State Board of
Education. The plan shall be updated annually if changes have been
made to the plan. ~~School districts shall not be required to~~

1 ~~electronically submit the annual updates to the Board if the last~~
2 ~~plan submitted to the Board was approved and expenditures for the~~
3 ~~program include only expenses relating to individual and small group~~
4 ~~tutoring, purchase of and training in the use of screening and~~
5 ~~assessment measures, summer school programs, and Saturday school~~
6 ~~programs. If any expenditure for the program is deleted or changed~~
7 ~~or any other type of expenditure for the program is implemented, the~~
8 ~~school district shall be required to submit the latest annual update~~
9 ~~to the Board for approval.~~ The district strong readers plan shall
10 include a plan for each site which includes an analysis of the data
11 provided by the Oklahoma School Testing Program and other reading
12 assessments utilized as required in this section, and which outlines
13 how each school site will comply with the provisions of the Strong
14 Readers Act.

15 2. The State Board of Education shall adopt rules for the
16 implementation and evaluation of the provisions of the Strong
17 Readers Act. The evaluation shall include, but not be limited to,
18 an analysis of the data required in subsection ~~B~~ S of this section.

19 F. ~~1. Any first-grade, second-grade, or third-grade student~~
20 ~~who demonstrates proficiency in reading through a grade-level~~
21 ~~appropriate screening instrument approved pursuant to subsection B~~
22 ~~of this section shall not require a program of reading instruction~~
23 ~~or an individual reading intervention plan. After a student has~~
24 ~~demonstrated proficiency through a screening instrument, the~~

1 ~~district shall provide notification to the parent or legal guardian~~
2 ~~of the student that he or she has satisfied the requirements of the~~
3 ~~Strong Readers Act. The district shall continue to monitor the~~
4 ~~student in the next successive grade level to ensure he or she~~
5 ~~maintains proficiency.~~

6 ~~2. Beginning with the 2025-2026 school year, if a third-grade~~
7 ~~student is identified at any point of the academic year as having a~~
8 ~~significant reading deficiency, which shall be defined as not~~
9 ~~meeting grade-level targets on a screening instrument administered~~
10 ~~pursuant to subsection A of this section, the district shall provide~~
11 ~~the student with intensive intervention services for the appropriate~~
12 ~~amount of the instructional day consistent with the individual~~
13 ~~reading intervention plan developed pursuant to paragraph 2 of~~
14 ~~subsection D of this section and as determined by the Student~~
15 ~~Reading Proficiency Team. Intensive intervention services shall~~
16 ~~continue until the student demonstrates proficiency at his or her~~
17 ~~grade level based on a screening instrument administered pursuant to~~
18 ~~subsection A of this section.~~

19 ~~G.~~ 1. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year:

20 a. if a first-grade student has demonstrated the need for
21 reading intervention services and is not meeting
22 grade-level targets by the end of the first grade, the
23 district shall place the student in a stand-alone
24 transitional second-grade classroom or promote the

1 student to second grade while providing targeted
2 transitional intervention instruction in pull-out
3 sessions, and

4 b. if a second-grade student has demonstrated the need
5 for reading intervention services and is not meeting
6 grade-level targets by the end of the second grade,
7 the district shall place the student in a stand-alone
8 transitional third-grade classroom or promote the
9 student to third grade while providing targeted
10 transitional intervention instruction in pull-out
11 sessions.

12 2. If a student is subject to the provisions of paragraph 1 of
13 this subsection, the family of the student shall be provided with
14 the option for the student to attend a summer tutoring program or a
15 summer reading academy. The State Department of Education shall
16 also approve one or two online or workbook-based summer tutoring
17 programs for use by students under this paragraph. School districts
18 shall also provide the parents or legal guardians of the student
19 with a list of summer literacy programs available if a summer
20 academy, as described in Section 1210.508E of this title, is not
21 offered by the school district.

22 G. Each school district shall annually report in an electronic
23 format to the State Department of Education, the Office of
24 Educational Quality and Accountability, and the Secretary of

1 Education the number of students in kindergarten through third grade
2 per grade level who exhibit grade-level reading proficiency, the
3 number of students per grade level who received intensive reading
4 intervention services pursuant to ~~paragraph 2 of~~ subsection ~~F~~ D of
5 this section, the number of students per grade level who attended a
6 summer academy as provided for in Section 1210.508E of this title,
7 the number of students per grade level who exhibited improved
8 reading proficiency after completion of intensive reading
9 intervention services, and the number of students per grade level
10 who are still in need of intensive reading intervention services.
11 The State Department of Education shall publicly report the
12 aggregate and district-specific numbers submitted pursuant to this
13 subsection on its website and shall provide electronic copies of the
14 report to the Governor, Secretary of Education, President Pro
15 Tempore of the Senate, Speaker of the House of Representatives, and
16 to the respective chairs of the committees with responsibility for
17 common education policy in each legislative chamber.

18 H. The parent or legal guardian of any student who is found to
19 have a reading deficiency ~~and is not meeting grade-level reading~~
20 ~~targets~~ and has been provided a program of reading ~~instruction~~
21 intervention services as provided for in paragraph 1 of subsection D
22 of this section shall be notified in writing ~~of~~ no later than thirty
23 (30) days after the identification of the reading deficiency. The
24 notification shall be accompanied by the individual reading

1 intervention plan developed in paragraph 2 of subsection D of this
2 section. The notification shall include the following:

3 1. That the student has been identified as having a ~~substantial~~
4 ~~deficiency in reading~~ deficiency;

5 2. A description of the current services that are provided to
6 the student pursuant to subsection D of this section;

7 3. A description of the proposed ~~intensive~~ reading intervention
8 services and supports that will be provided to the student that are
9 designed to remediate the identified area of reading deficiency as
10 provided for in ~~paragraph 2 of subsection F~~ D of this section;

11 4. That the parent or legal guardian shall be informed in
12 writing of the progress of the student toward grade-level reading at
13 least every thirty (30) days and provided with strategies to assist
14 at home;

15 5. That if the child's reading deficiency is not remediated by
16 the end of third grade, the child shall not be promoted to fourth
17 grade unless a good-cause exemption is met;

18 6. That a student who is promoted to the fourth grade for good
19 cause shall receive ~~supplemental intensive~~ reading intervention
20 services unless he or she is a student who meets the definition of a
21 student with the most significant cognitive disabilities;

22 ~~5. Strategies~~ 7. A description of the specific skill deficits
23 of the child and strategies for parents or legal guardians to use in
24 helping their child succeed in reading proficiency; and

~~6.~~ 8. The grade-level performance scores of the student; and

9. That while the statewide English Language Arts assessment is the initial determinate for promotion, students may be provided with an alternative reading assessment option that is recommended by the Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability and approved by the State Department of Education to demonstrate sufficient reading skills for promotion to fourth grade.

I. No student may be assigned to a grade level based solely on age or other factors that constitute social promotion.

J. 1. Any incoming third-grade student identified with a reading deficiency shall be provided reading intervention services to remedy his or her specific reading deficiency. Intervention services shall include effective instructional strategies to accelerate student progress and be delivered by a highly qualified teacher.

2. Public school districts shall review individual reading intervention plans for all incoming third-grade students identified with a reading deficiency. The review shall address additional supports and services the student will receive. The supports and services shall include reading instruction and reading intervention services and supports to correct any identified area of reading deficiency.

K. 1. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year, third-grade students shall demonstrate sufficient reading skills for promotion

1 to fourth grade. Students shall be provided the following options
2 to demonstrate sufficient reading skills for promotion to fourth
3 grade:

- 4 a. scoring above the below basic level on the third-grade
5 statewide English Language Arts assessment, or
- 6 b. earning an acceptable score on an alternative
7 standardized reading assessment as recommended by the
8 Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability
9 and approved by the State Board of Education.

10 2. If the third-grade student cannot demonstrate sufficient
11 reading skills on one of the two options described in paragraph 1 of
12 this subsection and does not qualify for a good-cause exemption, the
13 student shall be retained in the third grade for the next school
14 year. Screening instruments described in this section shall not be
15 used for promotion purposes.

16 L. The school district board of education may only exempt
17 students from mandatory third-grade retention, as provided in
18 subsection K of this section, for good cause. A student who is
19 promoted to fourth grade with a good-cause exemption, except for
20 students who meet the definition of a student with the most
21 significant cognitive disabilities, shall continue to receive
22 reading intervention services that includes specific reading
23 strategies prescribed in the student's individual reading
24 intervention plan until the deficiency is remedied. The school

1 district shall assist schools and teachers with the implementation
2 of reading strategies that research has shown to be successful in
3 improving reading among students with reading difficulties. Good-
4 cause exemptions shall be limited to the following:

5 1. Students identified as English language learners who have
6 had less than two (2) consecutive years of instruction in an
7 English-learner program;

8 2. Students with disabilities who participate in the statewide
9 English Language Arts assessment and who have an individualized
10 education program (IEP) that reflects that the student has received
11 intensive reading intervention for more than two (2) years but still
12 demonstrates a reading deficiency, or who was previously retained
13 for one (1) year in kindergarten, first, second, or third grade; and

14 3. Students who have received reading intervention services for
15 two (2) or more years but still demonstrate a reading deficiency,
16 and who were previously retained in kindergarten, first, second, or
17 third grade for a total of two (2) years. No student shall be
18 retained twice in third grade.

19 M. Requests to exempt students from the mandatory third-grade
20 retention requirement, as provided in subsection K of this section,
21 using one of the good-cause exemptions, as described in subsection L
22 of this section, shall be made consistent with the following:

23 1. Documentation shall be submitted from the student's teacher
24 to the school principal indicating that the promotion of the student

1 is appropriate. Such documentation shall consist only of the good-
2 cause exemption being requested and the existing reading
3 intervention plan or IEP;

4 2. The school principal shall review and discuss the
5 recommendation for exemption with the student's teacher. If the
6 principal determines that the student meets one of the good-cause
7 exemptions based on the discussion and documentation provided, the
8 school principal shall make such recommendation in writing to the
9 school district superintendent. The school district superintendent
10 shall accept or reject the school principal's recommendation in
11 writing; and

12 3. The parents or legal guardians of a third-grade student
13 eligible for a good-cause exemption may choose that the student be
14 retained for one (1) year even if the school district superintendent
15 accepts a recommendation for a good-cause exemption pursuant to this
16 subsection.

17 N. The school district shall provide written notification to
18 the parent or legal guardian of any student who is retained. Such
19 notification shall state that his or her child has not met the
20 reading level required for promotion to the fourth grade, the
21 reasons the child is not eligible for a good-cause exemption, and
22 that his or her child will be retained in third grade. The
23 notification shall include a description of the proposed reading
24

1 intervention services that will be provided to the child to remedy
2 the identified areas of reading deficiency in the retained year.

3 O. 1. Students that are withdrawn from public school to bypass
4 third-grade retention requirements, as outlined in subsection K of
5 this section, shall be subject to screening upon return to the
6 public school system to determine appropriate grade level upon re-
7 entry.

8 2. If a third-grade student subject to retention as provided
9 for in subsection K of this section transfers to a public school
10 district, a charter school, or a virtual charter school, the
11 requirements to retain the student in third grade shall not be
12 altered by the receiving school.

13 P. Beginning with the 2027-2028 school year, students retained
14 under the provisions of subsection K of this section shall be
15 provided reading intervention services to remedy the student's
16 specific reading deficiency. The reading intervention services
17 shall include effective instructional strategies to accelerate
18 student progress. Each school district shall conduct a review of
19 student reading intervention plans for all students retained in
20 third grade. The review shall address additional supports and
21 services needed to remedy the identified areas of reading deficiency
22 and ensure the following are provided to retained students:

23 1. A teacher with appropriate training and demonstrated
24 competency in evidence-based reading intervention. School districts

1 with only one third-grade teacher are exempt from the requirements
2 of this paragraph;

3 2. Reading intervention services and supports to correct the
4 identified areas of reading deficiency;

5 3. One of the following intervention supports:

6 a. a transitional instructional setting designed to
7 produce learning gains sufficient to meet fourth-grade
8 performance standards in all other core academic areas
9 while continuing to correct the areas of reading
10 deficiency,

11 b. before- or after-school supplemental research-based
12 reading intervention delivered by a teacher or tutor
13 with specialized reading training, or

14 c. summer academy programs designed to ensure that
15 participating students successfully complete grade-
16 level competencies in reading to enhance next-grade
17 readiness; and

18 4. A "Read at Home" plan as created by the Office of
19 Educational Quality and Accountability shall be outlined in a
20 parental or legal guardian notification, including participation in
21 parent or legal guardian training workshops or regular parent-guided
22 or legal guardian-guided home reading activities which are aligned
23 to scientifically based reading research.

1 Q. 1. Each school district board of education shall annually
2 publish on the school website and report electronically to the State
3 Department of Education, the Office of Educational Quality and
4 Accountability, and the Secretary of Education by September 1 of
5 each year the following information on the prior school year:

6 a. the policies and procedures adopted by the school
7 district board of education to implement the
8 provisions of this section. The information submitted
9 shall include expenditures related to implementing the
10 provisions of this section, the number of staff
11 implementing the provisions of this section, and
12 average daily classroom time devoted to implementing
13 the provisions of this section,

14 b. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in
15 kindergarten through third grade who ~~did not meet~~
16 ~~grade-level targets~~ demonstrated a reading deficiency
17 based on a screening instrument administered pursuant
18 to subsection A of this section,

19 c. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in
20 kindergarten through third grade who have been
21 enrolled in the district for fewer than two (2) years,

22 d. by grade, the number and percentage of all students in
23 kindergarten through third grade who were retained,
24

1 e. by grade, the number and percentage of students in
2 kindergarten through third grade who demonstrated
3 grade-level proficiency based on a screening
4 instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of
5 this section, ~~and~~

6 ~~e.~~

7 f. by grade, the number and percentage of students in
8 kindergarten through third grade who are on an
9 individualized education program (IEP) in accordance
10 with the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act
11 (IDEA) and who demonstrated grade-level proficiency
12 based on a screening instrument administered pursuant
13 to subsection A of this section or an alternative
14 assessment prescribed by the student's IEP,

15 g. the number and percentage of all students in third
16 grade who demonstrated sufficient reading skills for
17 promotion to the next grade on the alternative reading
18 assessment,

19 h. the number and percentage of students in third grade
20 who were promoted to fourth grade for good cause and
21 the applicable good-cause exemption specified in
22 subsection L of this section, and

23 i. the performance of fourth-grade students on the
24 statewide English Language Arts assessment who were

1 promoted with a good-cause exemption in the previous
2 school year.

3 2. The State Department of Education shall establish a uniform
4 format for school districts to report the information required in
5 this subsection. The format shall be developed with input from
6 school districts and shall be provided not later than ninety (90)
7 days prior to the annual due date. The Department shall annually
8 compile the information required, along with state-level summary
9 information, and electronically report the information to the
10 public, the Governor, the Secretary of Education, the President Pro
11 Tempore of the Senate, and the Speaker of the House of
12 Representatives and shall post such information on its website.

13 ~~K.~~ R. The State Department of Education shall provide technical
14 assistance as needed to aid school districts in administering the
15 provisions of the Strong Readers Act.

16 ~~L.~~ S. On or before January 31 of each year, the State
17 Department of Education shall electronically submit to the Governor,
18 the President Pro Tempore of the Senate, the Speaker of the House of
19 Representatives, and members of the committees with responsibility
20 over common education in both houses of the Legislature a Strong
21 Readers Report which shall include, but is not limited to, trend
22 data detailing three (3) years of data, disaggregated by student
23 subgroups to include economically disadvantaged, major racial or
24

1 ethnic groups, students with disabilities, and English language
2 learners, as appropriate for the following:

3 1. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in
4 kindergarten through third grade determined to be at risk for
5 reading difficulties compared to the total number of students
6 enrolled in each grade;

7 2. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in
8 kindergarten who continue to be at risk for reading difficulties as
9 determined by the year-end administration of the screening
10 instrument required in subsection A of this section;

11 3. The statewide aggregate number and percentage of students in
12 kindergarten through third grade who have successfully completed
13 their program of reading instruction and are reading on grade level
14 as determined by the results of a screening instruments instrument
15 administered pursuant to subsection A of this section;

16 4. The statewide aggregate and district-specific number and
17 percentage of students that meet or do not meet grade-level targets
18 for reading based on a screening instruments instrument administered
19 pursuant to subsection A of this section;

20 5. The statewide aggregate and district-specific number and
21 percentage of students that were retained in third grade;

22 6. The amount of funds received by each district for
23 implementation of the Strong Readers Act;

1 ~~6.~~ 7. An evaluation and narrative interpretation of the report
2 data analyzing the impact of the Strong Readers Act on students'
3 ability to read at grade level;

4 ~~7.~~ 8. The type of reading instruction practices and methods
5 currently being used by school districts in the state;

6 ~~8.~~ 9. Socioeconomic information, access to reading resources
7 outside of school, and screening for and identification of learning
8 disabilities for students not reading at the appropriate grade level
9 in kindergarten and first through third grade;

10 ~~9.~~ 10. By grade level, the types of intensive intervention
11 efforts being conducted by school districts for students who are not
12 on an IEP and who are not reading at the appropriate grade level and
13 for students who are on an IEP and who are not reading at the
14 appropriate grade level; and

15 ~~10.~~ 11. Any recommendations for improvements or amendments to
16 the Strong Readers Act.

17 The State Department of Education may contract with an
18 independent entity for the reporting and analysis requirements of
19 this subsection.

20 ~~M.~~ T. Copies of the results of the screening ~~instruments~~
21 instrument administered pursuant to subsection A of this section
22 shall be made a part of the permanent record of each student.

SECTION 5. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508D,
as amended by Section 6, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
2025, Section 1210.508D), is amended to read as follows:

Section 1210.508D. A. Contingent on the provision of
appropriated funds designated for the Strong Readers Act, ~~school~~
~~districts may be allocated monies for each enrolled kindergarten~~
~~student or first, second, and third grade student of the current~~
~~school year who is found to be in need of remediation or intensive~~
~~intervention services in reading. The allocation shall be~~
~~distributed to each school district upon approval of the strong~~
~~readers plan for the school district by the State Board of Education~~
~~and the submittal of a child count report to the State Department of~~
~~Education that details the number of students identified as needing~~
~~remediation or intensive intervention services in reading. To~~
~~determine a per-student allocation amount, the total amount of funds~~
~~available for allocation each year shall be divided by the total~~
~~number of students in the state identified as in need of remediation~~
~~or intensive intervention services in reading as provided for in~~
~~Section 1210.508C of this title. Each school district shall be~~
~~allocated an amount equal to the per student allocation amount~~
~~multiplied by the number of identified students enrolled in the~~
~~school district.~~

B. ~~Beginning with the 2022-2023 school year, districts~~
~~receiving more than Two Thousand Five Hundred Dollars (\$2,500.00)~~

~~pursuant to subsection A of this section shall spend no less than ten percent (10%) to provide professional development for teachers teaching prekindergarten through grade five. The professional development shall include training in the science of reading including how students learn to read; training in providing explicit and systematic instruction in phonological awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension; implementing reading strategies that research has shown to be successful in improving reading among students with reading difficulties; and instructional materials required for implementation.~~

~~C. By June 30, 2022, the Department shall approve and publish a list of professional development programs that are evidence-based and directly address the cognitive science of how students learn to read for which districts are permitted to use the funds received under this section.~~ each school district shall receive a base literacy allocation calculated on a per-student basis for each student enrolled in kindergarten and grades one through three, as reported in the October 1 enrollment counts of the current school year.

The base literacy allocation shall support the prevention of reading deficiencies and the implementation of strong core literacy instruction within Tier 1 of a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS) framework, including, but not limited to:

1 1. Evidence-based core literacy instruction and instructional
2 materials aligned with the science of reading;

3 2. Universal screening and diagnostic assessment necessary to
4 identify students at risk for reading deficiencies;

5 3. Progress monitoring and data use to inform instructional
6 decisions;

7 4. Family literacy resources and engagement activities aligned
8 with classroom instruction; and

9 5. Professional development and instructional coaching
10 necessary to implement the district strong readers plan.

11 The State Board of Education shall allocate not less than forty
12 percent (40%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section to
13 support the base literacy allocation described in this subsection.

14 B. 1. In addition to the base literacy allocation provided
15 pursuant to subsection A of this section, school districts shall
16 receive supplemental weighted funding for students identified
17 through screening and progress-monitoring data as requiring
18 additional reading intervention services within a multi-tiered
19 system of supports (MTSS) framework.

20 2. Supplemental weighted funding shall support intervention
21 services beyond Tier 1 core instruction and shall be distributed
22 according to the following categories:

23 a. Tier 2 - Supplemental Intervention Weight: Students
24 identified as requiring targeted reading intervention

beyond core instruction shall generate supplemental
funding to support additional instructional time,
reduced group size, and evidence-based intervention,
and

b. Tier 3 - Intensive Intervention Weight: Students
identified as demonstrating a significant reading
deficiency requiring intensive, individualized, or
highly targeted intervention shall generate
supplemental funding reflecting the increased
instructional intensity required at this level.

3. Supplemental funding received pursuant to this subsection
shall be used exclusively for intervention services beyond Tier 1
core instruction, including:

- a. additional instructional time devoted to reading
intervention,
- b. reduced instructional group sizes necessary to deliver
intensive instruction,
- c. specialized instructional materials and intervention
programs aligned with the science of reading,
- d. compensation for educators delivering intervention
services, and
- e. professional development necessary to ensure educators
providing intervention services have extensive
training in the science of reading.

1 4. The State Board of Education shall allocate not less than
2 thirty percent (30%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this
3 section to support supplemental weighted intervention funding
4 described in this subsection and shall promulgate rules establishing
5 the methodology for calculating weights, documentation requirements,
6 and procedures for verifying intervention participation.

7 5. Students shall be counted for purposes of supplemental
8 weighted funding pursuant to this subsection only when the school
9 district has documented that the student is receiving intervention
10 services consistent with the level of instructional intensity
11 required at the applicable tier.

12 6. School districts shall maintain documentation demonstrating:

- 13 a. identification of the student through an approved
14 universal screening assessment and supporting
15 diagnostic or progress-monitoring data,
16 b. implementation of an intervention plan specifying the
17 instructional approach, frequency, duration, and group
18 size of intervention services, and
19 c. ongoing progress monitoring used to determine the
20 effectiveness of the intervention and inform
21 instructional adjustments.

22 7. Students shall not generate supplemental weighted funding
23 unless intervention services are provided beyond Tier 1 core
24 instruction. The State Department of Education may review

1 intervention documentation and program implementation to verify
2 eligibility for supplemental weighted funding distributed pursuant
3 to this section.

4 8. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules
5 establishing reasonable expectations for the proportion of students
6 receiving supplemental and intensive intervention services within a
7 multi-tiered system of supports framework.

8 9. When the reported percentage of students receiving Tier 2 or
9 Tier 3 intervention services significantly exceeds expected ranges,
10 the State Department of Education may require additional
11 documentation or provide technical assistance to ensure intervention
12 services are implemented with the instructional intensity required
13 at each tier.

14 C. 1. In order to encourage continuous improvement in student
15 reading outcomes and to support the sustainability of effective
16 intervention services, a portion of funds appropriated pursuant to
17 this section shall be used to provide incentives to school districts
18 demonstrating measurable improvement in student reading performance.

19 2. Incentive funding may include recognition of:

- 20 a. students who demonstrate sufficient progress to exit
21 Tier 3 intensive intervention,
22 b. students who demonstrate sufficient progress to exit
23 Tier 2 supplemental intervention, and
24

1 c. schools or districts demonstrating measurable
2 reductions in the number or percentage of students
3 requiring supplemental or intensive intervention.

4 3. The State Board of Education shall allocate up to thirty
5 percent (30%) of funds appropriated for purposes of this section for
6 literacy improvement incentives and shall promulgate rules
7 establishing criteria for determining eligibility for such
8 incentives.

9 ~~D. If a teacher attends and completes a professional~~
10 ~~development institute in elementary reading approved by the~~
11 ~~Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability during the~~
12 ~~summer or when school is not in session, the teacher may receive a~~
13 ~~stipend equal to the amount of the cost for a substitute teacher,~~
14 ~~based on the amount of funds allocated.~~

15 SECTION 6. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508E,
16 as amended by Section 7, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S. Supp.
17 2025, Section 1210.508E), is amended to read as follows:

18 Section 1210.508E. A. If a teacher determines that a student
19 in kindergarten or first through third grade is not reading at grade
20 level by the end of the second quarter of the school year, the
21 parent or legal guardian of the student shall be notified of:

- 22 1. The reading level of the student;
23 2. The program of reading instruction for the student as
24 required pursuant to the Strong Readers Act; and

1 3. The potential need for the student to participate in a
2 summer academy or other program designed to assist the student in
3 attaining grade-level reading skills.

4 B. A teacher who determines a student in kindergarten or first
5 through third grade is not meeting grade-level targets for reading
6 may, after consultation with the parent or legal guardian of the
7 student, recommend that the student participate in and complete a
8 transitional instructional setting, before-, during-, or after-
9 school supplemental tutoring, a summer academy program, or other
10 program.

11 C. Summer academy programs shall be designed to ensure that
12 participating students successfully complete grade-level
13 competencies in reading to enhance next-grade readiness. A summer
14 academy reading program shall be a program that incorporates ~~the~~
15 ~~content of a scientifically research-based professional development~~
16 ~~program administered by the Commission for Educational Quality and~~
17 ~~Accountability or a scientifically research-based reading program~~
18 ~~administered by the State Board of Education~~ reading intervention
19 services and is taught by ~~teachers who have successfully completed~~
20 ~~professional development in the reading program~~ a highly qualified
21 teacher or who are a certified as reading specialists specialist.
22 The program shall provide explicit, systematic, sequential, and
23 cumulative reading intervention services and supports to correct
24 students' identified areas of reading deficiency.

1 D. School districts may approve an option for students who are
2 unable to attend a summer academy. The optional program may
3 include, but is not limited to, an approved private provider of
4 instruction, approved computer- or Internet-based instruction, or an
5 approved program of reading instruction monitored by the parent or
6 legal guardian. School districts shall not be required to pay for
7 the optional program but shall clearly communicate to the parent or
8 legal guardian the expectations of the program and any costs that
9 may be involved.

10 E. ~~Subject to the availability of funds, beginning 1.~~ School
11 districts shall provide at least one of the following reading
12 intervention options to all third-grade students scoring at the
13 below basic achievement level on the third-grade statewide English
14 Language Arts assessment, as well as students who have completed
15 kindergarten through second grade and are at risk of reading
16 deficiency as determined by a screening instrument administered
17 pursuant to subsection A of Section 1210.508C of this title:

18 a. before-, during-, or after-school supplemental
19 research-based reading intervention delivered by a
20 teacher or tutor with specialized reading training, or

21 b. summer academy programs designed to ensure that
22 participating students successfully complete grade-
23 level competencies in reading to enhance next-grade
24 readiness.

1 2. Summer reading academies shall include, at a minimum,
2 seventy (70) hours of instructional time in reading and shall not
3 use balanced literacy and whole language models, such as three-
4 cueing as defined in subsection F of Section 1210.508B of this
5 title.

6 F. Beginning one (1) year after implementation of this section,
7 the requirements of subsection ~~B~~ E of this section ~~may~~ shall be
8 expanded to apply to students in fourth grade. Each year
9 thereafter, the requirements ~~may~~ shall be expanded by one grade
10 level until the requirements apply to third-grade students through
11 eighth-grade students. ~~Summer academy programs~~ The reading
12 intervention options outlined in subsection E of this section shall
13 be designed for each grade level. Nothing in this section shall
14 prevent the State Board of Education or a school district board of
15 education from utilizing private, local, or federal funds to
16 implement this section.

17 ~~F.~~ G. The State Board of Education shall adopt rules to
18 implement the provisions of this section ~~which shall include~~
19 ~~requirements for instructional time for summer academy programs,~~
20 ~~teacher qualifications, and evaluation of student achievement as a~~
21 ~~result of summer academy programs or other optional programs~~ and
22 shall require school districts to report on the availability of
23 reading intervention options, the number of students participating
24

1 in each option, and evaluation of student achievement as a result of
2 each provided option.

3 SECTION 7. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 1210.508F,
4 as last amended by Section 3, Chapter 297, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S.
5 Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508F), is amended to read as follows:

6 Section 1210.508F. A. The Commission for Educational Quality
7 and Accountability shall ensure that the reading competencies for
8 elementary teachers are included in the competencies for special
9 education teachers.

10 B. The Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability in
11 collaboration with the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education
12 shall ensure that all teachers ~~and adjuncts~~ of early childhood
13 education, elementary education, and special education are provided
14 quality training in intervention, instruction, and remediation
15 strategies in the science of reading to provide explicit and
16 systematic instruction in phonological awareness, decoding, fluency,
17 vocabulary, and comprehension and implement reading strategies that
18 research has shown to be successful in improving reading among
19 students with reading difficulties. Professional development may
20 include effective use of data, progress monitoring, and intervention
21 planning as it fits into a multi-tiered system of supports (MTSS)
22 framework. In addition, quality education for prospective teachers
23 shall be provided in research-based instructional strategies for
24 instruction, assessment, and intervention for literacy development

1 for all students including advanced readers, typically developing
2 readers, and struggling readers who are coping with a range of
3 challenges including, but not limited to, English language learners,
4 students at risk for reading deficiencies, and ~~learners~~ students
5 with handicapping conditions and learning disabilities, including
6 dyslexia. Quality training shall include guidance from professional
7 resources such as the Report of the National Reading Panel, Response
8 to Intervention guidelines, and professional organizations such as
9 the Council for Exceptional Children, International Dyslexia
10 Association, International Literacy Association, National Council of
11 Teachers of English, and National Association for the Education of
12 Young Children.

13 C. All institutions within The Oklahoma State System of Higher
14 Education that offer elementary, early childhood education, or
15 special education programs approved by the Commission for
16 Educational Quality and Accountability shall incorporate into those
17 programs the requirement that teacher candidates study the five
18 elements of reading instruction which are phonological awareness,
19 decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension and study methods
20 based on the science of reading. Teacher candidates shall study
21 strategies including, but not limited to, instruction that is
22 explicitly taught, sequenced, multimodal (reading, writing,
23 speaking, listening, hands-on, etc.), multidisciplinary, and
24 reflective to adapt for individual learners. Additionally, teacher

1 candidates shall study the negative impacts of balanced literacy and
2 whole language models, including three-cueing practices. They shall
3 further study how to identify balanced literacy and whole language
4 models including three-cueing practices in curriculum, and
5 subsequently, learn how to implement reading instruction using high-
6 quality instructional materials grounded in the science of reading
7 which do not include balanced literacy and whole language models
8 such as three-cueing, and the negative impacts of three-cueing.

9 D. Each teacher education program approved by the Commission
10 for Educational Quality and Accountability shall be audited by the
11 Commission to ensure teacher candidates are receiving quality
12 training in the science of reading. The Commission shall place the
13 accreditation of any noncompliant teacher education program on
14 probationary status and provide guidance for exiting probationary
15 status.

16 E. Effective July 1, 2025, any person seeking initial
17 certification in a special education, early childhood education, or
18 elementary education program in this state shall be required to
19 successfully complete a comprehensive reading instruction assessment
20 approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and
21 Accountability as a condition for certification. The assessment
22 shall be aligned to scientifically based reading research and
23 evaluate the certification applicant's knowledge and understanding
24

1 of the five elements of reading instruction which are phonological
2 awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension.

3 ~~E.~~ F. Candidates applying for adjunct positions, an alternative
4 placement teaching certificate, or an emergency teaching certificate
5 in elementary education shall complete instruction in the science of
6 reading as determined by the Commission for Educational Quality and
7 Accountability and the State Board of Education.

8 SECTION 8. AMENDATORY Section 2, Chapter 288, O.S.L.
9 2023, as amended by Section 9, Chapter 411, O.S.L. 2024 (70 O.S.
10 Supp. 2025, Section 1210.508H), is amended to read as follows:

11 Section 1210.508H. A. Beginning with the ~~2023-2024~~ 2026-2027
12 school year, the State Department of Education shall establish and
13 maintain a ~~three-year pilot~~ program to employ a literacy
14 ~~instructional team~~ coaches to support school districts in
15 implementation of the requirements of Section 1210.508C of this
16 title. The Department shall provide technical assistance for
17 literacy instruction, dyslexia, and related disorders, and serve as
18 a primary source of information and support for schools,
19 administrators, and teachers in addressing the needs of students
20 struggling with literacy, reading deficiencies, or dyslexia, ~~and~~
21 ~~related disorders~~ or identified with the risk characteristics
22 associated with dyslexia.

23 B. The Department shall employ a literacy ~~instructional team~~
24 ~~with team members~~ coaches who are placed ~~regionally~~ in six major

1 geographic regions across the state. The literacy ~~instructional~~
2 ~~teams~~ coaches shall assist schools, administrators, educators, and
3 general education and special education teachers in recognizing
4 educational needs to improve literacy outcomes for all students
5 including those with reading deficiencies or dyslexia or identified
6 with the risk characteristics associated with dyslexia. Priority
7 shall be given to the lowest performing schools on the end-of-year
8 English Language Arts assessment or the statewide reading screener
9 as approved by the State Department of Education. The role of the
10 literacy ~~instructional team~~ coaches shall also include increasing
11 professional awareness and instructional competencies to meet the
12 educational needs of all students including those with reading
13 deficiencies or dyslexia or identified with risk characteristics
14 associated with dyslexia. The Department shall prioritize supports
15 and interventions including enrollment in reading trainings and
16 professional development for schools which have the highest
17 percentage of students who do not demonstrate sufficient reading
18 skills as established by the State Board of Education.

19 C. Literacy coaches shall provide systems and instructional
20 support to schools to strengthen the implementation of evidence-
21 based literacy instruction and intervention and to build the
22 capacity of educators and school leaders to sustain effective
23 literacy practices. Literacy coaches shall serve in a supportive,
24

1 non-evaluative capacity and shall not conduct personnel evaluations
2 or impose personnel actions.

3 D. Literacy ~~instructional team members~~ coaches employed by the
4 Department shall be required to pass Oklahoma's Foundations of
5 Reading test and shall have training in:

6 1. The science of how students learn to read including
7 phonological awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary, comprehension,
8 writing, and language;

9 2. Foundation of multisensory, explicit, systematic, and
10 structured reading instruction;

11 3. Identification of and the use of appropriate interventions,
12 accommodations, assistive technology, and teaching techniques for
13 ~~struggling~~ students with dysgraphia, dyslexia, a related reading
14 disorder, or reading deficiency;

15 4. The requirements of the Strong Readers Act;

16 5. Special education laws and procedures; and

17 6. Appropriate interventions, accommodations, and assistive
18 technology supports for students with dyslexia or a related
19 disorder.

20 ~~D.~~ E. The literacy ~~instructional team members~~ coaches employed
21 by the Department shall report to the Program Director for Literacy
22 at the Department and ~~have:~~

23 1. ~~A~~ shall consist of a minimum of five twenty regional
24 literacy ~~leads~~ coaches, at least one who shall be designated by the

1 Department as a dyslexia specialist to provide school districts with
2 support and resources that are necessary to assist students with
3 dyslexia. The Department shall give preference to educators
4 applying for regional literacy ~~lead~~ coaches who:

- 5 1. a. hold a master's degree in education with three (3)
6 years of documented successful experience teaching
7 reading as evidenced by reading assessment scores, or
8 b. hold a bachelor's degree with five (5) years of
9 documented successful experience teaching reading as
10 evidenced by reading assessment scores with a minimum
11 of three (3) years of literacy experience at the
12 state, district, or school level;

13 2. Have a valid certificate to teach issued by the State Board
14 of Education;

15 3. Have experience delivering professional development specific
16 to literacy instruction, mentoring and coaching classroom teachers,
17 leading others in a collaborative process, and analyzing and using
18 student performance data for instructional purposes;

19 ~~have~~ 4. Have an endorsement or certification as a certified
20 structured literacy dyslexia specialist or certified academic
21 language therapist~~;~~

22 ~~b. are~~

23 5. Are knowledgeable of multitiered systems of support~~;~~ and

24 ~~e. have~~

1 6. Have been trained in the identification of and ~~intervention~~
2 ~~for dyslexia and related disorders including best practice~~ the use
3 of appropriate interventions and ~~treatment models for,~~
4 accommodations, and teaching techniques for students with
5 dysgraphia, dyslexia; and

6 2. A minimum of ten literacy specialists, a related reading
7 disorder, or reading deficiency.

8 F. 1. The State Department of Education shall assign literacy
9 coaches to school districts that are identified by the Department
10 based on the number and percentage of students scoring in the below
11 basic performance level on the statewide third-grade assessment
12 administered pursuant to Section 1210.508C of this title or the
13 statewide reading screener in kindergarten through second grade.

14 2. If a district already employs instructional coaches, that
15 district shall not be required to utilize Department-assigned
16 literacy coaches so long as the local instructional coaches
17 participate in a Department-led coaching improvement community
18 aligned to the science of reading and national coaching best
19 practices.

20 G. Literacy coaches assigned to school districts pursuant to
21 the provisions of this section shall:

22 1. Provide technical support to teachers responsible for
23 reading instruction and reading specialists;
24

1 2. Assist administrators, educators, and reading specialists in
2 implementing evidence-based literacy practices;

3 3. Design and conduct professional development to meet the
4 needs of teachers and administrators in the area of literacy;

5 4. Provide clear, practical, timely, and candid written and
6 oral feedback to teachers and administrators based on coaching
7 cycles; and

8 5. Meet regularly with teachers, reading specialists, and
9 administrators to review literacy data and make recommendations for
10 adjustments in instructional practices.

11 H. The Department shall give preference to educators applying
12 ~~for literacy specialist~~ to become a literacy coach who:

13 ~~a.~~ have

14 1. Have training in the science of reading~~r;~~

15 ~~b.~~ are

16 2. Are knowledgeable of ~~multitiered~~ multi-tiered systems of
17 support~~, and;~~

18 ~~c.~~ have

19 3. Have been trained in the identification of and ~~intervention~~
20 ~~for dyslexia and related disorders including best practice~~ the use
21 of appropriate interventions ~~and treatment models for,~~
22 accommodations, and teaching techniques for students with
23 dysgraphia, dyslexia, a related reading disorder, or reading
24 deficiency; and

1 4. Have previously retired and were a highly effective
2 elementary school teacher based on student reading scores on the
3 statewide English Language Arts assessment or teacher evaluations.

4 I. If a school district that is prioritized for supports and
5 interventions pursuant to this section declines to accept assistance
6 from a literacy coach, the district shall not be eligible to receive
7 funds pursuant to Section 1210.508D of this title.

8 J. 1. School districts shall have a minimum of one reading
9 specialist, interventionist, or staff member with an early literacy
10 micro-credential for each public elementary school.

11 2. For school districts who do not currently employ or contract
12 with a reading specialist or interventionist, the Office of
13 Educational Quality and Accountability, in collaboration with the
14 State Department of Education, shall work with public or private
15 institutions of higher education within this state to develop
16 teacher training academies for teachers to obtain an early literacy
17 micro-credential. The academies shall provide a competency-based
18 professional learning micro-credential after completing an intensive
19 teacher training academy held at Oklahoma-based universities.

20 3. The teacher training academies developed pursuant to
21 paragraph 2 of this subsection may include in-person instruction,
22 synchronous online, or hybrid options. The intensive academy shall
23 be focused on MTSS, the science of reading, and standards alignment
24 for early literacy instruction in kindergarten through third grade.

1 Districts shall select at least one staff member per school, with
2 priority given to districts without a current full- or part-time
3 reading specialist or interventionist, per year to attend the
4 teacher training academies. These individuals can be teachers and
5 full- or part-time interventionists who will work with students in
6 kindergarten through third grade.

7 4. The Office of Educational Quality and Accountability shall
8 set program criteria for the micro-credential course and vet higher
9 education programs seeking to issue the credential to Oklahoma
10 educators. The Commission for Educational Quality and
11 Accountability shall approve higher education institutions allowed
12 to issue an early literacy micro-credential. Both public and
13 private higher education institutions may apply.

14 5. Instructors for teacher training academies shall possess
15 relevant field experience, including demonstrated recent practice in
16 the field.

17 6. The State Department of Education shall fund a stipend of
18 Three Thousand Dollars (\$3,000.00) for up to one staff member per
19 school serving students in kindergarten through third grade to
20 attend and receive an early literacy micro-credential. The
21 Department shall fund any public or private higher education
22 institution approved by the Commission for Educational Quality and
23 Accountability with One Thousand Five Hundred Dollars (\$1,500.00)
24

1 per kindergarten through third grade staff member that attends and
2 receives an early literacy micro-credential.

3 ~~E.~~ K. The State Department of Education shall electronically
4 submit a report to the Governor, the President Pro Tempore of the
5 Senate, and the Speaker of the House of Representatives by December
6 31, 2026, that includes an evaluation of the pilot program by school
7 districts, data on whether the program had an impact on increasing
8 the number of students who demonstrate proficiency in reading, and
9 recommendations for changes to the Strong Readers Act.

10 SECTION 9. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified
11 in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 1210.508J of Title 70, unless
12 there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

13 A. There is hereby created in the State Treasury a revolving
14 fund for the State Department of Education to be designated the
15 "Strong Readers Revolving Fund". The fund shall be a continuing
16 fund, not subject to fiscal year limitations, and shall consist of
17 all monies received by the State Department of Education from
18 private businesses, nonprofit organizations, and federally
19 recognized Indian tribes or nations. All monies accruing to the
20 credit of the fund are hereby appropriated and may be budgeted and
21 expended by the State Department of Education for the purpose of
22 improving reading outcomes in accordance with the Strong Readers
23 Act. Expenditures from the fund shall be made upon warrants issued
24 by the State Treasurer against claims filed as prescribed by law

1 with the Director of the Office of Management and Enterprise
2 Services for approval and payment.

3 B. Donors to the Strong Readers Revolving Fund shall designate
4 a specific school, school district, or region to receive their
5 donation. The State Department of Education shall distribute monies
6 from the Strong Readers Revolving Fund in strict compliance with
7 donor designations required by this subsection.

8 C. Monies in the Strong Readers Revolving Fund may be expended
9 for implementation support services, teacher training, data
10 integration, evaluation, reporting, micro-credential stipends and
11 program fees, and professional learning, to support statewide MTSS
12 implementation goals.

13 SECTION 10. It being immediately necessary for the preservation
14 of the public peace, health or safety, an emergency is hereby
15 declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and
16 be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

17

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